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Sujatha Rao shares her moving yet hopeful journey of living with Fibromyalgia

I woke up on the morning of 18th April, 2019, with excruciating pain down the entire right side of my body. My arm and leg felt as if they were on fire. I was consumed by fear. I screamed out my husband's name, tears streaming down my face. He ran into the room anxious. "I cannot move" I cried.

For the next half hour, he sat next to me, rubbing my arms and legs, slowly massaging my neck, head, and shoulders until the pain began to subside. I could move my fingers, my toes, and slowly, very slowly move my arms. At the end of the hour, despite the pain that I felt in my neck, shoulders, arms, and legs, I felt an overwhelming sense of relief.

Since about 2016, I have felt pain in my shoulders, neck, base of my skull, and arms. As a facilitator and organizational development (OD) practitioner, I dedicated substantial time to computer work and extended periods of standing during workshops. I believed this routine contributed to physical imbalances in my body. I first went to see an orthopaedic doctor who suggested that I have an x-ray. The report suggested mild spondylitis and the doctor recommended physiotherapy with exercises for relief. Despite following this regimen for over six months, my neck, shoulder, and arm pain persisted, leading me to question the diagnosis.

I had suffered from migraine headaches for several years and was familiar with the debilitating nature of migraines. I went to see a neurologist and he suggested that

my migraine aura — the starting point and nature of the spread of the pain — had changed over time. While earlier, I would feel the pain across my forehead, the side of my head and eyes, now the aura of the pain had shifted to the base of the skull, at the junction of the spinal cord and skull and radiated across my arms.

I was overjoyed to hear this! Now I felt I knew what was causing the pain in my neck, shoulders and arms. It was migraine!

The neurologist prescribed migraine medications and neuro-relaxers to alleviate nerve tension. Despite starting treatment, my neck, shoulder, and back pain persisted, fluctuating between manageable days and debilitating episodes.

I began to go to sleep with a singular wish every night — let me wake up pain-free in the morning.

Early in 2018, my father was diagnosed with Pulmonary Fibrosis. It was devastating news for my family. My father was an active, energetic man, who continued to work well into his 70s. An outgoing, cheerful man, he went from walking 4–5 km every day to being on 24 hours of oxygen support in a matter of months.

My parents lived with me and each day I felt my father's deterioration. I felt his pain and his struggle for a single breath of oxygen. A sense of hopelessness engulfed me. I tried to remain cheerful and optimistic — I had a family to take care of and work that kept me sane. But the stress took a toll on me.

I felt the pain in my body, particularly in my shoulders, arms and back increase significantly. I tried yoga exercises, stretching, taking breaks frequently from work, but the pain persisted.

My husband's work required that he move to Singapore at the beginning of 2018, and I felt a sense of loneliness and isolation from the situation with my father. My father passed away towards the end of November 2018. My family was going through distressing times, and I felt the pain of this. In April 2019 my daughter and I went to Singapore to visit my husband. I landed in Singapore on April 17th. On the 18th, I woke up in bed, in extreme pain and fear.

I went to see a GP in Singapore to explain what happened and seek a diagnosis. He asked me to see a rheumatologist to get an expert opinion.

The Rheumatologist talked to me about my pain and history. At the end of her examination, she said “You have fibromyalgia”. I had never heard of this and had no understanding of this illness. But as soon as she had a diagnosis, I felt this overwhelming sense of relief. At last, I had a name for what I was experiencing, even if I did not understand it completely.

I spent the next few days reading up about fibromyalgia. My first instinct was to try and find answers to two questions — how did I end up with Fibromyalgia and what can I do to cure myself from this? Fibromyalgia is broadly a disorder characterised by widespread musculoskeletal pain. It falls under the broad spectrum of auto-immune, but it is characterised by the brain amplifying painful sensations. I understood this cognitively. But emotionally, I struggled to understand this. I felt I had to understand and treat this condition better. I was back in India, and I met with other doctors, did some blood tests, tried ayurvedic massages and treatments, met with homeopaths and neurologists.

Most approached this from their own siloed perspectives — “It is the gut” the ayurvedic practitioner said. “No, the nervous system”, the neurologist said. “Increase Vitamin D” my GP said seeing the blood report. Sometimes I encountered scepticism, with one doctor telling me that it was probably a general “women's condition” — something I did not understand at all.

There was no particular reason why someone could develop fibromyalgia and there was no specific cure. It seemed I had to live with this pain or ‘manage it’ as the doctor said, for the rest of my life.

I began to realise that Fibromyalgia is a strange beast. It has a voracious appetite to consume its host — not through any form of degeneration or degradation of the body and cells but through relentless pain and the capturing of the mind of the host — it builds fear and a sense of dejection.

Every day I woke up and the first thought in my head would be — what is paining today? My head, neck, shoulder, jaw, arms? I did a checklist of body part pain every morning and developed my measurement index — 1 for pain that I could try and ignore and 5 for excruciating pain that forced me back into bed. I would swing from sadness to anger to frustration to dejection all in one day. I would snap at helpful advice, want to wallow in my miserable pain, and often feel hopeless. But my family and friends rallied behind me. My husband would suggest useful remedies every day, from pain relief balms to visits with chiropractors; my daughter would do helpful massages, and close friends would call and cheer me up.

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I also began to see the connections between gut health and body pain.



What I ate mattered. I began to experiment with a more vegan diet, with more greens and less carbohydrates. I ate more consciously and more slowly.

I saw the interconnections between and emotional well-being and physical pain. I understood how emotional stress affected the body. I began to understand the

importance of good posture, a good diet, regular exercise (yoga/walking), of regular breaks — both physically stepping away from work and mentally (to stop thinking of work and other stressors altogether!).

I realised how good conversations, companionships, a cup of tea with a friend, and watching an interesting show on TV all made moments of ‘good’ for me. I sensed that the days when I was connected with nature, surrounded by water, birds, trees — were good. I still hurt, but for some reason, my brain helped take my attention away from the pain allowing me to enjoy myself and be ‘pain-free’.

I became much more aware of myself — my thoughts, my daily actions, the food that I put in my mouth, the feelings that I experienced. I began to feel more in control of myself and consequently in control of this illness. I began to feel that Fibromyalgia cannot conquer me. This ‘thing’ has been a tyrannical, yet thoughtful teacher.

Through my experience with Fibromyalgia, I have realised that everything is connected. Our thoughts and lived realities, the feelings, and emotions that they evoke, the actions that they motivate in us, all influence our physical health and wellbeing. I have learnt that I am deeply connected and dependent on other human beings. We affect and support each other. Our joys and distresses are interconnected.

I have learned to be open, vulnerable, and honest because in doing that, my honesty and vulnerability have been reciprocated. Family and friends have been unstintingly compassionate. Colleagues have been so considerate of my needs — from food requirements to working arrangements. Doctors have provided helpful

information. Other people with Fibromyalgia have shared their insights and I have benefitted from their generosity of sharing. I have learned to appreciate my body, my feelings my thoughts and my belief systems. This morning, I woke up and did my pain-index check. It feels like a mild 2!



I get up and do my stretches. I know the sea is waiting for me to walk alongside it and as I walk and listen to podcasts and think of interesting things happening in the world, my brain will help me forget my pain.

I know that even though Fibromyalgia will not leave me, I can ‘leave’ it many times during the day. Maybe half an hour here or an hour there. Together they add up — these moments when it does not affect me. And it is more than enough.

For me to smile, to laugh, to write, to talk, to read, to work.

To be fully human and look at life with hope, joy, and optimism.

I am changed.

Sujatha dreams of workplaces that are designed for humans and not machines. Currently, she lives in Singapore but works mostly with civil society organisations in India. Given a chance, would like to live a nomadic life, with a backpack and a good book!

She hosts an amazing podcast, listen to it here: <https://www.workwisepod.com/about>

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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.

